

World in Brief: Iran threatens to keep Hormuz shut; Houthi strike kills six



Photograph: Getty Images

The newly appointed secretary of **Iran's** Supreme National Security Council said the **Strait of Hormuz** would not reopen until America “changes its behaviour” and accepts Iran’s conditions for ending the war, according to Iranian state media. Iran is separately discussing with Oman a route through [the waterway](#) that would not fully reopen it. Donald Trump has dismissed Iran’s demand for compensation for war damage.

The **Houthis** said they attacked a cargo ship in the Bab al-Mandab strait that was transporting Saudi military equipment. The strike killed at least six people, the first deaths caused by a Houthi attack since the Iran war began. Last month the Iran-backed group [blockaded](#) Saudi Arabia’s Red Sea coast; it hit Saudi-linked tankers and attacked oil facilities.

Colombia declared a state of emergency after an **earthquake** killed at least 200 people. The epicentre of the 7.4-magnitude quake was in the western Chocó province, in the country’s coffee-growing region. It toppled buildings across the province, trapping many under the rubble. The cities of Cali, Pereira and Manizales were all affected. Officials warned the death toll is likely to rise.

A court in Syria sentenced **Bashar al-Assad**, [the country's former president](#), to death in absentia for committing “crimes against humanity” during Syria’s bloody civil war. Mr Assad fled to Russia after his regime was toppled in 2024. Atef Najib, Mr Assad’s cousin and a high-ranking general under the Assad regime, was also sentenced to death. Over 500,000 people died in the conflict.

Brad Lightcap, a top **OpenAI** executive who has worked for the company since 2018, said he was leaving “to start something new”. He did not share what that was. Mr Lightcap is one of several senior figures who has recently left the [artificial-intelligence lab](#). This year OpenAI filed for an [initial public offering](#).

More than 2,000 people have died from **Ebola** in the Democratic Republic of Congo, the World Health Organisation said. [The outbreak](#), which was declared in May, is the fastest growing on record. No vaccines or treatments are yet approved for this strain of the virus; overwhelmed health services are worsening its spread.

America’s president hid in a **catering container** in order to board a secret military flight from Turkey to Britain last month, according to new reports. Mr Trump departed [a NATO summit](#) in Ankara following an Iranian assassination threat. After boarding Air Force One in front of television cameras, he was smuggled onto a second plane via a cart used to transport in-flight meals.

Figure of the day: 2.25bn, the number of cups of coffee drunk across the world each day. But [climate change is putting your morning brew at risk](#).

Another test for the Democratic left



Photograph: Getty Images

Wisconsin's Democratic primary for governor takes place on Tuesday. Francesca Hong, a member of the state assembly and a Democratic Socialist, is the clear favourite; her closest challenger is David Crowley, a more centrist politician.

[America's populist left](#) is enjoying a red-letter summer. Last week Abdul El-Sayed, who calls himself a capitalist but draws support from the socialist crowd, won Michigan's Senate primary. Their success is in part thanks to full-throated campaigning. The Democrats' left wing skews young, and combines social-media savvy with a willingness to put boots on the ground.

Midterm elections in November will test whether such left-wingers can win enough centrist and independent voters. Ms Hong's opponents have highlighted her past tweets calling to abolish the police and "cancel Thanksgiving", suggestions she has since disavowed. Moderate Democrats say she could push swing voters into the Republicans' arms. Ms Hong may be a risky bet in an important battleground state.

Colombia's new president responds to disaster



Photograph: AP

Twenty-four hours after a four-minute-long, 7.4-magnitude earthquake shook western and southern Colombia, the scale of the tragedy is becoming clear. The quake has killed at least 160 people, injured more than 500 and damaged 1,575 buildings. Those numbers will rise. For Colombians there is a grim sense of déjà-vû. The earthquake was as strong as the pair that [hit neighbouring Venezuela](#) in June, killing thousands.

Colombia's authorities have acted more quickly than Venezuela's did. Three days into the job of president, [Abelardo de la Espriella](#) has pledged "unwavering determination" to contain the crisis. He declared a national disaster, allowing him to draw from the budget via decree, and dispatched his cabinet to the badly affected cities of Pereira, Cali and Quibdó, where the only hospital is overwhelmed. Soldiers have been deployed to deter looting. In Chocó, the region where the shock originated, victims will get housing aid. The Trump administration, which counts Mr de la Espriella as an ally, has allocated \$15.5m in relief.

Elbit Systems is as controversial as it is profitable

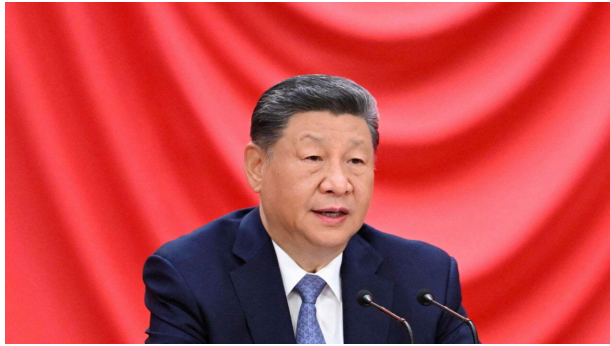


Photograph: Getty Images

Israel's biggest defence firm reported a strong second-quarter on Tuesday, with adjusted earnings up by about 28% compared with a year earlier. Underpinning Elbit Systems' growth is a record order backlog worth more than \$32bn. Roughly two-thirds of Elbit's earnings come from overseas, especially Europe, where there is [strong demand](#) for its electronic-warfare expertise and its command-and-control systems.

But the company's domestic deals have attracted criticism. In supplying Israel's armed forces with most of their land-based and unmanned aerial systems, Elbit has benefited from the high tempo of [operations in Gaza, the West Bank and Lebanon](#). That has made the company a target for human-rights groups and divestment campaigns, with some success. Barclays and HSBC, two big banks, as well as some European pension funds, have reportedly sold their shares in Elbit as a result. A deal announced last month to supply surveillance technology to America's Customs and Border Protection, worth \$370m, has further enraged Elbit's activist opponents.

China's leaders' seaside sojourn



Photograph: Alamy

President Xi Jinping and other Communist Party bigwigs have left behind a sweltering Beijing for a beachside resort in the town of Beidaihe. But they are not lazing about. Officials are sequestered at a secret annual conclave, holding important policy discussions on the economy and China's drive to become a science and technology superpower.

Economic growth unexpectedly slowed in the second quarter, to 4.3% compared with a year earlier, below the government's target of 4.5-5%. China's leaders will probably use their retreat to draft plans for greater fiscal support to boost the economy. The other focus appears to be the government's innovation push. Last week senior scientists and technologists were invited there to brief China's leaders, who are looking for ways to support scientific research, as promised in the government's latest [Five-Year Plan](#).

Orban-renewal in Hungary



Photograph: Getty Images

Hungary's parliament elected Andras Baka, a former head of the Supreme Court, as the country's president on Tuesday. Mr Baka was considered to be a shoo-in; he was nominated by Tisza, the party of [Peter Magyar](#), the prime minister, which has a two-thirds majority in parliament. In 2011 Fidesz, the party of Viktor Orban (Mr Magyar's predecessor), removed Mr Baka from the Supreme Court on spurious grounds, seemingly because of his criticism of Mr Orban's illiberal judicial reforms.

Hungary's president plays a largely symbolic role, but in this instance the symbolism is significant. Last month Mr Magyar removed Tamas Sulyok from the presidency through a constitutional amendment because he didn't want an "Orban puppet", as he put it, in the role. He proposed Judit Polgar, a chess champion, for the job, but Ms Polgar declined. With Mr Baka, Hungary will get a dissident of the Orban regime who has fought for the independence of the judiciary and the rule of law.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which London landmark, designed by Sir George Gilbert Scott, features sculptures representing four continents, and four arts and sciences, as well as of the central figure it is named after?

Monday: Which British political party, founded in 1900, produced prime ministers such as Ramsay MacDonald and Harold Wilson?

True originality consists not in a new manner, but in a new vision.

Edith Wharton